In the larger scheme of things, though, what were we achieving through this trans-LC firing? While we were inflicting casualties on the Pakistan Army, we too were suffering some casualties of our own. Added to that were the casualties being suffered by the locals residing in the border area and the psychological trauma that the men, women and children had to endure. There were conflicting views on whether to continue with these trans-LC operations or broker another ceasefire. When I was the Army Commander ARTRAC, I had spoken at a seminar organized by the Punjab University in February 2018, on the future of Indo–Pak relations. In my talk, while reviewing the state of relations between the two countries, I mentioned that the need of the hour was 'statesmanship, not brinkmanship', which immediately hit the headlines.[6] Some analysts even went so far as to opine that it showed a rift between Gen Bipin Rawat and his senior commanders in matters of policy. Even today, I stand by what I had said then because violence should be the last resort, the means to an end, and not the end itself.

During my interactions with the PM, the security situation in J & K, on the LC as well as the hinterland, always came up for discussion. In the hinterland, the overall law-and-order situation had improved considerably after the abrogation of Article 370 in August 2019. This was not mere wishful thinking but based on facts. Cases of stone-throwing and arson, shut-downs (bandhs), civilian killings, IED blasts, etc., had all shown a declining trend. There continued to be a few terrorist attempts to disturb the peace, but these were usually foiled through joint operations by the RR and J & K police. On the LC, the situation remained the same. Trans-LC fire assaults had reached a point of diminishing returns. Another facet that had escaped attention was the recurring costs imposed

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